



The reality of war

A photograph taken after the battle by Alexander Gardner shows Confederate dead lying near Dunker Church. Such images were a shock to a public unused to war photography.

McClellan's folly

Union luck appeared to change in the afternoon, with Lee facing potential disaster. Federal troops belatedly found a crossing to Lee's right at Snavelly's Ford. They threatened not only to stave in his right flank, but to cut off his only line of retreat to the Potomac River. Had McClellan committed all his forces at this moment he would surely have won the day but, ever cautious, he insisted on retaining his reserves—20,000 men who never fired a shot.

Lee was saved by the belated arrival of A. P. Hill's division, force-marched from Harpers Ferry. Its unexpected appearance on his flank led Burnside to withdraw prudently back across the creek. In the late afternoon, fighting ceased. There seemed every reason to expect that McClellan would resume his offensive the following day and achieve a decisive victory, but he did not. After some skirmishing,